

香港退休移民的社会网络及其对粤港澳大湾区迁移决策的动态影响

Social Networks and Migration Decisions of Hong Kong Retirees in the Greater Bay Area

摘要

随着香港人口老龄化问题的日益加剧，高昂的生活成本、有限的社会福利、紧张的医疗与护理资源迫使部分退休老人寻找新的养老方式。粤港澳大湾区（GBA）中的广东城市因其地理位置相近、较低的生活成本、丰富的医疗资源以及与香港文化的高度相似性，成为香港退休移民的首选目的地。目前约有九万香港退休人士长期居住在广东。然而，目前针对退休老人跨境迁移的研究大多聚焦于西方文化背景，少有研究分析华人群体在跨境迁移过程中社会网络的动态变化及其对决策的影响。本研究将社会网络视为贯穿迁移决策、迁移适应以及返港意图的关键因素，通过民族志访谈，探讨社会网络在这些环节中的功能与变化。研究将特别关注信息通信技术（ICT）在维系和扩展社会网络中的作用，并结合华人文化语境，提出理论深化与政策建议。

研究问题

社会网络如何影响香港退休老人迁移至大湾区的决策？迁移后，退休老人的社会网络如何变化？社会网络的变化对他们的生活有怎样的影响？社会网络的动态变化如何影响退休老人的返港意图？信息通信技术（ICT）在维系和拓展社会网络中扮演何种角色？

研究背景

1. 香港老龄化与养老困境

香港现已进入老龄化社会，65岁及以上人口占总人口的20%，预计到 2029 年，香港人口将达到顶峰约 800 万，其中老年人占总人口的 25%(Chan and Liang 2013)。与此相对的是，香港现有的社会福利制度和医疗护理体系难以承受老龄化带来的巨大压力。

香港是全球生活成本最高的城市之一。并由于被殖民历史，形成了政府对公共福利不关心、公民在公共议题不活跃的不干预主义传统(劉蜀永 2023)。再加上受传统孝道观念影响，多数香港老人习惯依赖家庭支持。然而，现代家庭结构和代际关系变化使得这一模式不再普遍。老年贫困成为了必然面临的社会问题(Choua, Chow, and Chi 2004)，退休老年人不得不依赖公立医疗与养老机构。

然而香港目前的医疗资源与长期护理资源短缺严重，香港每1000名人口中只有2.0名医生，不仅低于广东省（2.3名），也低于其他发达经济体(Health Bureau 2021)。公立医院的候诊时间极长，医疗供需失衡(劉蜀永 2023)。目前香港公立养老院的轮候时间超过两年，严重供不应求(于晓曼 and 吴泓锟 2024)。香港的公立医院与长期护理的费用主要来自公共支出，预计2033年，护理(Chung et al. 2009)与医疗(Leung, Tin, and Chan 2007)支出占据政府总预算比例很可能由2004年的19.6% 增至 36.8%，挤占其他重要的公共领域的拨款。

2. 粤港澳大湾区：跨境养老的潜在选择

Guangdong–Hong Kong–Macao Greater Bay Area，简称the Greater Bay Area (GBA)，指香港、澳门和广东的九个城市，这些城市文化相近、经济互补，2017年起开始进行更加深入的合作。后文中所指的大湾区为大湾区中的广东城市。GBA因其相对低廉的生活成本、充足的医疗资源以及与香港文化的相似性(Chiu and Ho 2005)，成为香港老人退休后的热门移居地。香港工会联合会的报告显示，超过87.9%的60岁以上的受访香港居民愿意在广东长期生活与养老(香港工会联合会 2023)，目前在广东长期生活的香港退休移民约有九万人左右(Census and Statistics Department, 2009)。

此外，香港与中国内地的政策进一步降低了移居的障碍。1997年开始，居住在广东的香港居民也可以领取Comprehensive Social Security Assistance (Social Welfare Department 2024) and Social Security Allowance(Social Welfare Department 2024)。2013年的Guangdong Scheme和2014年的广东院舍住宿照顾服务计划都为香港老人在内地养老提供了经济与设施的便利(Social Welfare Department 2021)。2015年开始，部分广东医院加入长者医疗券计划，(The Government of the Hong Kong Special Administrative Region 2024)，2021年起，GBA实现了医疗记录、药品与医疗器械的互通(中央人民政府驻香港特别行政区联络办公室 2021)，为香港老人提供更加便捷的医疗服务。然而，目前在大湾区生活的香港退休移民人数仍然不足十万，与其潜在规模相差甚远。本研究以香港退休移民为切入点，通过分析社会网络的动态变化，探索其对迁移决策、适应及返港意图的影响，为缓解香港老龄化压力与促进大湾区养老一体化提供多维支持。深入研究这一群体的迁移决策过程和生活适应有助于优化跨境养老政策，减轻香港的社会养老负担。本研究将丰富社会资本理论与迁移动力学模型的内涵，探索社会网络如何动态影响华人退休移民的跨境决策。研究结果可为促进大湾区养老服务一体化提供实证支持，并为ICT在老年人群体中的推广应用提供参考。

文献综述

1. 退休移民的国际视角与华人背景差异

退休移民通常指年龄超过退休年龄的群体，为追求更适宜的居住条件或生活方式，而非工作赚钱，自愿迁移至其他地区的现象（Walters, 2000）。在国际视角下，这一研究主要关注发达国家老年人向经济成本更低、气候更宜居地区的迁移。例如，北欧或英国的退休老人常迁往南欧的西班牙或意大利等地（Rodriguez et al., 2004; Casado-Díaz et al., 2004）。研究表明，退休移民的主要动因包括：降低生活成本、改善生活质量、获取更好的医疗服务以及追求社区归属感（Gustafson, 2001; Repetti et al., 2024）。

这些研究大多聚焦于发达国家的老年人迁移，且移民流向多以欠发达地区或度假目的地为主。在此背景下，移民者通常在经济上更具优势，因而研究主要集中于其社会整合过程及对本地社会的影响，如文化冲突与适应能力（Ciobanu et al., 2017; Calzada, 2018）。然而，这些研究以白人家庭为主体，很少关注文化背景差异较大的群体，如华人退休移民的独特性。在中国，退休移民因特定文化背景展现出显著差异。一方面，重视家庭的文化影响了老年人迁移的动因与方向。例如，“随子女移民”是华人退休移民的重要特点，父母常为照顾孙辈而迁往子女居住地（Da, 2003; Kobayashi & Preston, 2007）。另一方面，中国的区域性流动趋势明显，如城市居民迁往自然旅游资源更丰富的地区养老，以及农民工回流家乡的趋势，这些现象体现了养老与地域文化的深层次联系（吴悦芳 & 徐红罡, 2022）。

然而，这类研究多聚焦于中国内地，鲜少涉及香港退休老人迁移至粤港澳大湾区的独特现象。香港作为一座全球化城市，其移民行为既受到文化传统的深远影响，也受到政策、经济和跨境便利性的驱动，这与国内其他地区截然不同。

2. 社会网络与退休移民的迁移决策

社会网络是由社会关系构成的结构体系，包括个体间的互动、资源流动与信任机制（Wasserman & Faust, 1994）。社会网络能够提供关键信息，如就业、生活成本和政策环境（Granovetter, 1973）。社会资本（尤其是信任和互惠）通过密切的社会联系（如家庭关系）增强个体在不同情境下的资源获取和心理支持（Putnam, 2000）。

社会网络在移民决策与适应中均发挥重要作用。在迁移前期，已有研究表明，强关系（如家庭）通过提供经济支持与情感保障，显著提高了移民的意愿（Haug, 2008）。同时，弱关系（如朋友、社区）在提供迁移目标地的就业机会和社会服务信息方面尤为关键（Granovetter, 1973; Lin, 2001）。迁移后，社会网络的重构成为移民融入新环境的关键问题。一些研究显示，强关系网络（如亲密家人）更倾向于维系，但弱关系网络的变化则更加显著，尤其在陌生环境中，新网络的建立往往决定了移民的社会整合程度（Simó Noguera et al., 2013）。

社会网络对人的身心健康具有重要影响（Cattell 2001），针对退休人士的研究进一步表明，不论文化背景，多样化的社会网络都有益于老年人的身心健康（Chan and Lee 2006）。但具体来看，存在与西方的文化差异。针对西方老人的研究表明，子女主要提供工具性支持，朋友主要提供情感性支持（Seeman and Berkman 1988），有时朋友比子女更加重要（Fiori, Antonucci, and Cortina 2006）。但针对香港老人的研究表明，子女对老人的支持非常重要，与子女的关系很大程度上影响了香港老年人的生活质量（Ng, Phillips, and Lee 2002），老人与子女的关系远比其他类型的社会支持网络更重要（Chi and Chou 2001）。这对于退休移民来说尤为重要，因为跨境迁移常导致原有社会网络的部分丧失（Tomás and Molina 2024）。因此退休老人需要

维护原有的社会网络和发展新的社会网络。Information and communications technology (ICT) 和外籍人士社区能够提供帮助。

随着ICT的普及，数字技术成为社会网络维系的重要工具。Baldassar & Wilding (2020) 提出的“数字亲属 (Digital Kinning)”概念表明，数字通信在地理距离拉大的情况下能够帮助家庭成员维持情感联系。退休移民群体中，ICT尤其对远程支持网络 (distant support networks) 的建立具有积极作用。然而，老年人对ICT的使用在很大程度上受到数字素养的限制。部分研究指出，尽管技术可显著增强社会联系，但老年移民若未能充分掌握相关技术，可能加剧社会孤立和融入困难 (Baldassar & Wilding, 2020; Tomás & Molina, 2024)。在香港退休移民的背景下，ICT的作用仍需深入研究，尤其是其如何影响社会网络的扩展及其对迁移决策的反作用。

针对欧盟移民的研究表明，外籍人士社区与俱乐部为退休移民建立新的社会网络提供了很大帮助。通常加入相同社区或俱乐部的老年人会有相似的国籍、母语、阶级，社区与俱乐部可以提供各类信息和实际帮助，这类组织能够通过加强老年人间的团结，来更快地发展社会网络与社会资本，能够鼓励老年人做出移民决策 (Simó Noguera, Herzog, and Fleerackers 2013)。但在更加注重家庭关系的华人文化背景下，这类组织能否起到同样重要的作用，还有待研究。

3. 香港的退休移民研究

目前关于香港退休移民的研究相对较少，已有研究主要聚焦于移民与非移民的动因分析以及移居大湾区的可行性。Chou (2007) 的研究显示，45至59岁的中年人，受教育程度较高、从事白领工作、有非自住物业且不与子女同住的男性，最有可能考虑退休后迁往大湾区生活。Hui et al. (2011) 则指出，促使香港老年人选择移民的因素多样化，包括生活成本较低、文化背景相似以及代际关系等。然而，这些研究强调，没有任何单一因素足以完全解释移民的决策过程。大多数选择移居大湾区的老人符合 Amenity Retirement Migration Model (Bai & Chow, 2014) 的框架，即迁移动机主要基于提升生活质量的考虑。与此同时，研究也揭示了阻碍香港老人移民的关键因素。Cao and Fang (2019) 发现，香港的部分福利政策无法随移民携带至内地，这对移民意愿造成显著影响。此外，Dai (2023) 指出，尽管大湾区的医疗资源相对丰富，但部分老人认为内地的医疗费用较高且质量不可靠，这种不信任感进一步削弱了移民意愿 (Yan & He, 2023)。

除了动因分析外，也有学者关注退休移民的经济影响。Ma and Chow (2006) 的研究表明，香港退休老人移居大湾区对两地经济产生了截然不同的影响：对大湾区而言，这一迁移趋势带来了积极的经济贡献；但对香港本地经济可能造成一定程度的负面冲击。

尽管社会网络是移民研究的重要维度，但关于香港退休移民社会网络的研究仍相对稀缺。大多数现有研究集中于家庭成员之间的联系，特别是在 Covid-19 限制下，香港退休老人被迫滞留大湾区，与在香港的子女维持联系的情况 (He et al., 2023)。例如，周 (2023) 重点分析了特殊政策环境对家庭内部代际关系的影响，强调了数字技术在支持跨境联系中的作用。

然而，关于香港退休移民的非家庭成员社会网络研究则几乎空白。许多老人迁居大湾区后，其社会网络的重构主要依赖于社区组织和地方性社交活动，但这一领域尚未得到深入探索。同样，退休移民如何在日常生活中平衡维系家人联系和建立新社会网络的需求也缺乏系统研

究。这种研究空白表明，有必要进一步分析社会网络在退休移民决策、适应及其返迁意图中的复杂作用。

4. 研究差距与方向

通过文献综述可以发现，现有研究在以下方面存在不足：首先，退休移民的研究多以西方文化为背景，华人移民特别是跨境养老移民的特殊性尚未得到充分关注。其次，关于社会网络动态变化及其对迁移过程的影响，研究多集中于移民适应阶段，而忽视了迁移决策与返迁行为的整合分析。并且，信息通信技术在支持老年社会网络维系中的作用虽有研究，但在退休移民群体中的具体机制仍有待挖掘。最后，一些研究涉及到了香港退休移民的社会网络，但仅局限于家庭成员内部的联系，缺乏退休移民移居大湾区后的非家庭成员的社会网络的研究。因此，本研究将以香港至粤港澳大湾区的退休移民为切入点，探索社会网络的动态变化对迁移决策、迁移适应以及返港意图的综合影响。

理论框架

1. 理论基础

本研究整合以下理论框架，为分析社会网络与迁移行为之间的互动关系提供指导：

社会资本理论（Putnam, 2000）社会资本指通过社会网络获得的资源和支持，包括信任、互惠与规范。这一理论解释了社会网络在迁移决策中的资源性功能，特别是强关系的情感支持和弱关系的信息传递。

弱关系理论（Granovetter, 1973）弱关系是连接不同群体的桥梁，能够促进信息流动和机会获取。对于退休移民，弱关系在迁移适应和社会网络扩展中具有重要作用。关注弱关系在信息传播和资源获取中的关键作用，适用于解释迁移前后信息流的变化。

Amenity Retirement Migration Model(Haas and Serow 1993; Bai & Chow, 2014)该模型强调生活质量提升是退休移民的重要动力，包括经济优势、气候适宜性和文化亲近性。结合华人文化背景，本研究将进一步探讨社会网络在此模型中的作用机制。

数字技术适应理论（Baldassar & Wilding, 2020）该理论提出数字通信技术对维系远距离亲属关系的关键作用，并探讨了技术在社会网络动态中的中介角色。

2. 研究假设与分析路径

基于上述理论，本研究提出以下假设并构建理论分析框架：

迁移决策阶段

假设1：强关系（如家庭成员）通过提供情感支持与迁移建议，显著增强迁移意愿。

假设2：弱关系（如社区或跨境联系人）通过提供迁移目标地的信息与资源，降低迁移成本。

迁移适应阶段

老人通过数字技术和社区活动维护原有社会网络，同时建立新的弱关系网络。

假设3：老人通过ICT和社区活动等方式维持原有强关系网络，同时拓展弱关系网络，以增强社会适应能力。

假设4：社会网络的多样化有助于缓解孤独感并提升心理健康，提高老年人在GBA的居住意愿。

返迁意图阶段

社会网络的适应性变化直接影响迁移后的生活满意度和返港可能性。

假设5：社会网络的重构程度直接影响移民对目的地的满意度，进而决定其返迁意图。

数字技术的中介作用

假设6：ICT通过增强信息流动和社会互动，在社会网络维系与扩展中发挥重要中介作用。

理论框架可通过以下图示化模型呈现：

迁移前：原本的社会网络中强关系与弱关系共同作用，影响迁移去GBA的决策。

迁移后：原本的社会网络重构，通过ICT等中介进行维系与扩展，形成迁移适应的新的支持体系。

动态反馈：社会网络的变化影响返迁意图，同时对后续决策形成反馈回路。

研究方法

1. 研究设计

本研究采用质性研究方法，通过 ethnographic interviews 深入探讨香港退休移民的迁移过程及其社会网络的动态变化。比如退休移民的移民历史、生活故事、当前和过去的社会网络、电子设备的使用情况等。

2. 样本选择

目标群体:

首次迁移者: 退休后首次迁居GBA，每年居住时间超过六个月的老人。

双居老人: 指每年三到六个月在GBA生活，其余时间居住在香港的退休老人。

返港老人: 曾移居GBA但最终返回香港定居的老人。

样本规模: 计划访谈约30名参与者，覆盖不同年龄段（55-64岁、65-74岁、75岁以上）。

3. 数据采集

访谈内容: 迁移决策的影响因素。社会网络的组成与变化。ICT使用情况及其对社会联系的影响。田野地点: 深圳、广州、中山。研究显示，最受香港退休移民青睐的退休地点是深圳、广州和中山，同时这三个地方也都有加入医疗券计划的医院(The Government of the Hong Kong Special Administrative Region 2024)。研究者主要通过医院、养老院、社区、老年大学和私人关系来寻找研究对象。多数老年人由于有基础疾病，需要定期去医院进行治疗。香港政府的医疗券计划在大湾区有多个合作医院，研究人员可通过在医院观察的方式找到合适的研究对象。广东院舍照顾服务计划，指在香港有资格进入养老院轮候的老人，可以以较低的价格入住在广东的养老院，研究者可以在养老院实地探访寻找潜在的研究对象。通常情况下，年龄越大的老年人越有可能更需要专业护工照料，本场景中将更关注寻找74岁以上的高龄老人。大湾区养老的香港老人会有集中居住的社区，许多社区也会有专门针对老年人的服务，研究者可以通过探访特定社区来与研究对象取得联系。许多新闻报道指出，由香港移居到大湾区的退休老人，很喜欢发展个人爱好，老年大学作为内地较为普及且专门针对老年人探索爱好的机构，也可以成为研究者寻找研究对象的场地。

4. 数据分析

访谈数据将采用编码与主题分析法，从中提取迁移决策、网络适应及ICT应用的关键模式。

研究贡献

本研究能够拓展社会资本理论在跨境养老研究中的应用，阐释社会网络对迁移过程的动态影响。构建适合华人文化语境的退休移民分析框架，深化迁移动力学模型的内涵。为大湾区养老一体化政策提供实证支持，特别是在跨境医疗协作和老年社区服务方面。提供数字技术赋能老年社会融合的建议，促进ICT在老年人群体中的普及应用。

时间计划

第一阶段（1-3月）：文献综述与研究框架构建。

第二阶段（4-10月）：数据采集，包括访谈与田野调查。

第三阶段（11-14月）：数据分析与初稿撰写。

第四阶段（14-16月）：修改与提交最终报告。

Social Networks and Migration Decisions of Hong Kong Retirees in the Greater Bay Area

1. Statement of Purpose

As Hong Kong faces an increasingly aging population, the high living costs, limited social welfare, and strained healthcare and caregiving resources have compelled some retirees to seek alternative retirement arrangements. Guangdong cities in the Guangdong-Hong Kong-Macao Greater Bay Area (GBA) have become the top destination for Hong Kong retirees due to their lower cost of living, rich healthcare resources and high cultural similarity with Hong Kong. Currently, there are about 90,000 Hong Kong retirees living in Guangdong on a long-term basis. However, most of the previous studies on the cross-border migration of retirees focused on Western cultural contexts, and few analyzed the dynamic changes in the social networks of Chinese people during cross-border migration and its impact on decision-making. This study considers social networks as a key factor throughout the decision to migrate, adaptation to migration, and the intention to return to Hong Kong. Through ethnographic interviews, it explores the functions and changes of social networks in these processes. The research will pay particular attention to the role of information and communication technology (ICT) in maintaining and expanding social networks, and will propose further theoretical insights and policy recommendations in the context of Chinese culture.

2. Research Question

This study aims to examine the impact of social networks on the decision-making process of Hong Kong retirees migrating to Guangdong cities within the Guangdong-Hong Kong-Macao Greater Bay Area. Such decisions include the question of whether to relocate to Guangdong, whether to return to Hong Kong, and the period and frequency of returning. In particular, the study examines how retirees' social networks change after migration and the impact of such changes on their daily lives and willingness to return to Hong Kong. Furthermore, the study examines the role of information and communication technology (ICT) in maintaining and expanding social networks.

3. Introduction

3.1 Hong Kong's Aging Population and Challenges in Elderly Care

Hong Kong has evolved into an ageing society, with citizens aged 65 and over constituting 20% of the total population. By 2029, the population is expected to peak at approximately 8 million, with older adults comprising 25% of the total population (Chan and Liang, 2013). In contrast, Hong Kong's current social welfare and healthcare systems are struggling to cope with the significant pressures resulting from an ageing population.

Hong Kong has one of the highest costs of living in the world. Hong Kong's colonial history has developed a legacy of non-interventionism, in which the government is relatively unconcerned about public welfare and residents are generally disengaged from public affairs. In addition to traditional filial piety, most elderly adults in Hong Kong depend on familial support. Yet changes in modern family structures and intergenerational relationships have made this approach uncommon. The phenomenon of poverty among the elderly has emerged as a critical societal issue (Choua et al., 2004), with retired seniors frequently depending on public healthcare and pension systems to fulfil

their requirements. The elderly poverty has become a significant social problem, with retired senior people regularly depending on public medical and pension institutions to cover their needs.

However, Hong Kong is facing a significant shortage of medical and long-term care resources. Hong Kong has only 2.0 doctors per 1,000 individuals, which is lower than that of other developed economies and also below Guangdong Province's rate of 2.3 (Health Bureau, 2021). Public hospital (劉蜀永, 2023) and nursing homes (于晓曼 & 吴泓锟, 2024) wait times are so long, that there is a supply-demand imbalance for medical and long-term care services. Hong Kong's public hospitals and long-term care facilities are mostly supported by public funds. In 2033, the proportion of government expenditure on health care (Chung et al., 2009) and medical care (Leung et al., 2007) is predicted to rise from 19.6% in 2004 to 36.8%, straining financing for other critical public areas.

3.2 The Greater Bay Area: A Potential Option for Cross-Border Retirement

Guangdong–Hong Kong–Macao Greater Bay Area (GBA) refers to Hong Kong, Macao and nine cities in Guangdong with comparable cultures and complementing economies, which have begun to collaborate more closely since 2017. The GBA mentioned to in the following text are the Guangdong cities in the Greater Bay Area. The GBA has been a preferred retirement destination for Hong Kong residents due to its inexpensive living costs, adequate medical resources, and cultural similarities with Hong Kong (Chiu and Ho, 2005). According to a survey conducted by the Hong Kong Federation of Trade Unions, more than 87.9% of Hong Kong residents over the age of 60 are willing to live and retire in Guangdong for the long term (香港工会联合会, 2023). Approximately 90,000 retired Hong Kong immigrants have been residing in Guangdong for a long time (Census and Statistics Department, 2009).

Furthermore, policies about social welfare and medical care in Hong Kong and mainland China have reduced the barriers to migration. Since 1997, Hong Kong residents living in Guangdong have been able to receive Comprehensive Social Security Assistance (Social Welfare Department, 2024) and Social Security Allowance (Social Welfare Department, 2024). The Guangdong Scheme in 2013 and the Guangdong Residential Care Services Scheme in 2014 both provided Hong Kong elderly people with financial and infrastructure benefits for ageing on the GBA (Social Welfare Department, 2021). Beginning in 2015, some Guangdong hospitals joined the Elderly Healthcare Voucher Scheme. Since 2021, the GBA has interconnected medical records, pharmaceuticals, and medical devices (中央人民政府驻香港特别行政区联络办公室, 2021), allowing Hong Kong's elderly to receive more convenient medical care. However, the number of retired Hong Kong immigrants living in the Greater Bay Area remains less than 100,000, far from its potential size. This study focuses on Hong Kong retirees, analyzing the dynamic changes in their social networks to explore their impact on migration decisions, adaptation, and return intentions, providing multidimensional support to address Hong Kong's aging challenges and promote integrated elderly care in the Greater Bay Area.

4. Literature Review

4.1 International Perspectives on Retirement Migration and Chinese Contexts

Retirement migration is the voluntary movement of people over the retirement age to other locations in search of better living conditions or lifestyles, rather than working for money (Walters, 2000). From an international perspective, research has focused on the migration of older people from developed countries to regions with lower economic costs and more pleasant climates. For example, retired people from northern Europe or the UK often move to southern Europe, such as Spain or Italy (Rodriguez et al., 2004; Casado-Díaz et al., 2004). Research shows that the main motivations for retiring to a foreign country include lower living costs, a better life quality, better health care and the desire for a sense of community (Gustafson, 2001; Repetti et al., 2024).

Many of these studies examine the migration patterns of older individuals from developed nations to less developed areas or vacation locales. In this context, migrants are generally in a better financial position, so research focuses mainly on their social integration processes and the impact on local society, such as cultural conflicts and adaptability (Ciobanu et al., 2017; Calzada, 2018). However, these studies primarily focus on white families and rarely address groups with significant cultural differences, such as the distinctness of Chinese retired immigrants. Retired migrants in China differ significantly due to their diverse cultural backgrounds. On the one hand, culture of valuing family shapes the motivation and direction of the elderly's movements. For example, 'migration with children' is an important feature of Chinese retirement migration. Parents frequently relocate to where their children live to care for their grandchildren (Da, 2003; Kobayashi and Preston, 2007). On the other hand, there is a clear trend towards regional mobility in China, such as urban residents moving to areas with richer natural tourism resources for retirement, as well as migrant workers returning to their hometowns, which reflect the deep-rooted connection between retirement and regional culture(吴悦芳 & 徐红罡, 2022).

However, the majority of these studies focus on mainland China and rarely address the unique phenomenon of Hong Kong's retired elderly migrating to the GBA. As a global city, Hong Kong's migration behavior is deeply influenced by cultural traditions and driven by policies, the economy, and cross-border convenience, which is very different from the rest of the country.

4.2 Social Networks and Migration Decisions in Retirement Migration

Social networks are structural systems composed of social relationships, encompassing interactions, resource flows, and trust mechanisms (Wasserman & Faust, 1994). They provide critical information, such as employment opportunities, living costs, and policy environments (Granovetter, 1973). Social capital, particularly trust and reciprocity, enhances individuals' access to resources and psychological support in various contexts through close social ties, such as familial relationships (Putnam, 2000).

Social networks play a crucial role in both migration decision-making and adaptation. During the pre-migration phase, research has shown that strong ties, such as family, significantly enhance migration willingness by providing financial support and emotional security (Haug, 2008). At the same time, weak ties, such as friends and community networks, are particularly critical in offering information about employment opportunities and social services at the destination (Granovetter, 1973; Lin, 2001). Post-migration, the reconstruction of social networks becomes a key factor in integrating migrants into their new environment. Studies indicate that strong ties, such as close family members, are more likely to be maintained, while changes in weak ties are more pronounced. In unfamiliar settings, the establishment of new weak ties often determines the degree of social integration achieved by migrants (Simó Noguera et al., 2013).

Social networks significantly affect people's physical and mental health (Cattell, 2001). Studies on retirees suggest that diversified social networks promote the physical and mental health of older individuals, regardless of cultural background (Chan & Lee, 2006). However, there are cultural differences between the East and the West. Studies of elderly people in the West show that children provide primarily instrumental support, while friends provide primarily emotional support (Seeman & Berkman, 1988), and that friends are sometimes more important than children (Fiori et al., 2006). Despite this, studies on the elderly in Hong Kong have shown children support is very important, and that the elderly's relationship with children has a significant impact on their quality of life (Ng et al., 2002). The bond between the elderly and their children is far more important than other forms of social support (Chi & Chou, 2001). This is particularly crucial for retirement migrants, as crossing borders often results in the partial loss of their original social network (Tomás & Molina, 2024). Consequently, retirees must retain their existing social networks while also creating new ones. Previous research has shown that information and communication technology (ICT) and expatriate groups can help.

With the widespread adoption of ICT, digital technology has become a vital tool for maintaining social networks. The concept of "Digital Kinning," proposed by Baldassar & Wilding (2020), highlights how digital communication enables family members to sustain emotional connections despite geographic separation. Among retirement migrants, ICT plays a particularly positive role in establishing distant support networks. However, the use of ICT among older adults is significantly constrained by their level of digital literacy. Some studies suggest that while technology can greatly enhance social connections, older migrants who lack sufficient ICT skills may face increased social isolation and difficulties in integration (Baldassar & Wilding, 2020; Tomás & Molina, 2024). In the context of Hong Kong retirement migrants, the role of ICT warrants further investigation, especially regarding its impact on the expansion of social networks and its reciprocal influence on migration decisions.

Research in the EU has shown that expatriate communities and clubs are of particular help to retired migrants in establishing new social networks. Older people who join the same community or club usually have similar nationalities, native languages and social classes. Communities and clubs can provide various types of information and practical help. Such organizations can strengthen solidarity among older people, which can lead to faster development of social networks and social capital, and encourage older people to make decisions about migration (Simó Noguera et al., 2013). However, it remains to be seen whether such organizations can play an equally crucial role in the Chinese cultural context, which places greater emphasis on family relationships.

4.3 Studies on Retirement Migration in Hong Kong

There have been little studies on Hong Kong retirees and migrants. Existing research has mostly examined the motivations of migrants and non-migrants, as well as the practicality of relocating to the Greater Bay Area. According to Chou's (2007) research, males between the ages of 45 and 59 who have a higher level of education, white-collar occupations, non-owner-occupied residences, and do not live with their children are more likely to consider retiring and relocating to the Greater Bay Area. Hui et al. (2011) pointed out that the factors that prompted Hong Kong's elderly to choose to immigrate were diverse, including a lower cost of living, similar cultural backgrounds, and intergenerational relationships. However, these research highlighted that no single component can fully explain the immigration decision-making process. Most senior adults who decide to relocate to the Greater Bay Area match the Amenity Retirement Migration Model (Bai & Chow, 2014), which states that their main motivation for migrating is to improve their quality of life. At

the same time, research has also revealed key factors hindering the emigration of Hong Kong's elderly. Cao and Fang (2019) found that some of Hong Kong's welfare policies cannot be taken to the mainland with migrants, which has a significant impact on their willingness to emigrate. Furthermore, Dai (2023) stated that, while medical resources in the Greater Bay Area are quite numerous, some older people consider that medical costs on the mainland are excessive and the quality is questionable. This skepticism further reduces their willingness to migrate (Yan & He, 2023).

Although social networks are an essential aspect of migration studies, research on the social networks of Hong Kong's retired migrants remains limited. Most of previous study has concentrated on family relationships, particularly in the setting of COVID, when retired Hong Kong immigrant were required to remain in the Greater Bay Area while maintaining touch with their children in Hong Kong (He et al., 2023). For example, Zhou (2023) examines the influence of the specific policy circumstances on intergenerational relationships within families, emphasizing the importance of digital technology in facilitating cross-border contacts.

However, there is almost no research on the social networks of non-family members of Hong Kong's retired migrants. After many older people relocate to the Greater Bay Area, the rebuilding of their social networks is mostly dependent on community organizations and local social activities, but this field has yet to be thoroughly researched. Also, there has been no systematic research into how retired migrants combine the desire to keep contact with their family with the need to form new social networks in their everyday life. The research gap highlights the need for further investigation into the complex role of social networks in the decision-making, adaptation, and return intentions of retired migrants.

4.4 Research Gaps

The literature review revealed that the available research has the following deficiencies: Most studies on retirement migrants are conducted within a Western cultural context, and the unique characteristics of Chinese migrants, particularly cross-border retirement migrants, have received little attention. Also, most studies on the dynamic changes in social networks and their impact on the migration process focus on migrants' adaptation stages, ignoring the integrated examination of migration decisions and return migration behaviors. Furthermore, although the role of information and communication technology in maintaining the social networks of the elderly has been studied, the specific mechanisms among retired migrant groups have yet to be explored. Finally, while some studies have examined the social networks of Hong Kong retirees, they have been limited to connections among family members, with no research on the social networks of non-family members of retirees who have relocated to the Greater Bay Area. As a result, this study will use retired Hong Kong migrants in the Guangdong-Hong Kong-Macao Greater Bay Area as a starting point to investigate the complex influence of dynamic changes in social networks on migrating decisions, adaption, and intention to return to Hong Kong.

5. Theoretical Framework

This study integrates four theoretical frameworks, Social Capital Theory, Weak Ties Theory, Amenity Retirement Migration Model to guide the analysis of the interaction between social networks and migration behavior:

Social capital refers to the resources and support derived from social networks, including trust, reciprocity, and norms(Putnam, 2000). This theory explains the resource-based functions of social networks in migration decision-making, particularly the emotional support provided by strong ties and the informational benefits of weak ties. Weak ties serve as bridges connecting different groups, facilitating the flow of information and access to opportunities(Granovetter, 1973). For retirement migrants, weak ties play a crucial role in migration adaptation and the expansion of social networks. This theory highlights the importance of weak ties in information dissemination and resource acquisition, making it particularly relevant to understanding the flow of information before and after migration.

The Amenity Retirement Migration Model emphasizes the pursuit of improved quality of life as a primary driver for retirement migration, encompassing economic benefits, favorable climates, and cultural affinity(Haas & Serow, 1993; Bai & Chow, 2014). By incorporating the Chinese cultural context, this study further explores the role of social networks in the mechanisms underlying this model. Digital Technology Adaptation Theory highlights the critical role of digital communication technologies in maintaining long-distance familial relationships and examines their mediating role in the dynamics of social networks(Baldassar 2016; Baldassar & Wilding, 2020) .

These frameworks collectively provide a robust basis for analyzing how social networks influence migration decisions, adaptation processes, and the interplay between digital technology and social capital in the context of retirement migration. Based on the aforementioned theories, this study proposes the following hypotheses and constructs an analytical framework:

Migration Decision Phase

Social networks and other factors drive the elderly to make migration decisions.

Hypothesis 1: Strong ties (e.g., family members) significantly enhance migration willingness by providing emotional support and migration advice.

Hypothesis 2: Weak ties (e.g., community or cross-border contacts) reduce migration costs by offering information and resources about the destination.

Migration Adaptation Phase

Elderly migrants maintain their original social networks and establish new weak ties through digital technology and community activities.

Hypothesis 3: The elderly sustain their original strong ties and expand weak ties through ICT and community activities, thereby enhancing their social adaptation capabilities.

Hypothesis 4: The diversification of social networks helps alleviate loneliness, improve psychological well-being, and increase their willingness to reside in the GBA.

Return Intention Phase

The adaptability of social networks directly influences post-migration life satisfaction and the likelihood of returning to Hong Kong.

Hypothesis 5: The degree of social network reconstruction directly affects migrants' satisfaction with the destination, which in turn determines their intention to return.

Mediating Role of Digital Technology

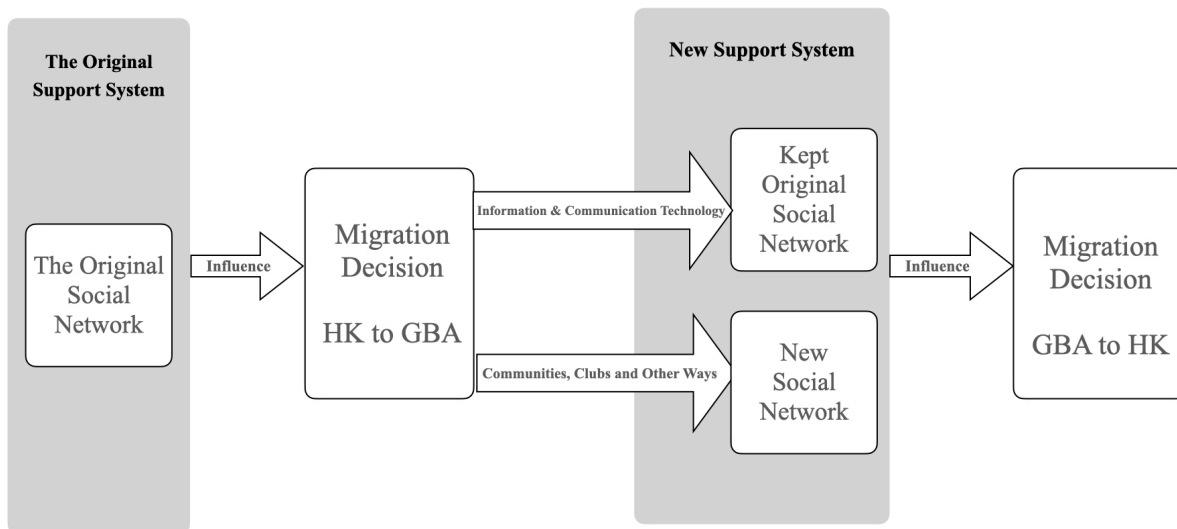
Hypothesis 6: ICT plays a crucial mediating role in maintaining and expanding social networks by enhancing information flow and social interaction.

Illustrated Theoretical Framework:

Pre-Migration: In the original support system, strong and weak ties within the original social network jointly influence the decision to migrate to the GBA.

Post-Migration: Social networks are reconstructed and maintained through mediators such as ICT, forming a new support system for migration adaptation.

Dynamic Feedback: Changes in social networks impact the intention to return to Hong Kong, while also creating feedback loops that influence subsequent decisions.



Picture 1 : Illustrated Theoretical Framework

6. Research Methods

6.1 Research Design

Through ethnographic interviews, this study uses a qualitative research approach to investigate in detail the migration process of retired migrants from Hong Kong and the dynamic changes in their social networks. Topics covered include the retired migrants' migration history, life stories, current and previous social networks, and their use of electronic devices.

6.2 Sample selection

Target group:

First-time migrants: Elderly people who have moved to the GBA for the first time after retirement and live there for more than six months a year.

Bi-residents: Retired people who spend three to six months a year in the GBA and the rest of the year in Hong Kong.

Returnees: People who have lived in the GBA but have eventually returned to Hong Kong.

Sample size: It is planned to interview around 30 participants, covering different age groups (55-64 years old, 65-74 years old, over 75 years old).

6.3 Data Collection

Interview topics included variables influencing migration decisions, the makeup and changes in social networks, and the impact of ICT usage on social networks.

Field locations include Shenzhen, Guangzhou, and Zhongshan. According to research, the most popular retirement locations for Hong Kong retirees are Shenzhen, Guangzhou, and Zhongshan, all of which include hospitals that participate in the medical voucher plan (The Government of the Hong Kong Special Administrative Region 2024). The researchers mostly sought research subjects from hospitals, nursing homes, communities, universities for the aged, and personal relationships.

7. Original Contribution

It provides empirical support for the Greater Bay Area's eldercare integration policy, particularly in the areas of cross-border medical collaboration and elderly community services. Suggestions for digitally empowering social integration for the elderly encourage the widespread use of ICT among the elderly.

8. Research Timeline

Phase 1 (months 1-3): Literature review and construction of research framework.

Phase 2 (months 4-10): Data collection, including interviews and field research.

Phase 3 (months 11-14): Data analysis and writing of first draft.

Phase 4 (months 14-16): Revision and submission of final report.

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